The failure to protect Buddhism is now seen by many pro-Buddhist commentators as the major failing of British rule—they criticise the British for failing in their duty as rulers to protect and promote Buddhism as an integral part of Burmese culture.[36] This attitude is derived from Theravada Buddhism's notion that the strength of the religion is reliant on a state that is committed to its protection.[37]

Arakan

While historical Arakan started to interact with the kingdoms of central Burma from the eleventh century onwards, the area was formally independent of Burma up to the end of the eighteenth century. However, the Rohingyas' dominance in the region ended with the arrival of the largely Buddhist Rakhine from central Burma[38] around 1000 AD. The Rakhine also incidentally share a Tibeto-Burmese ancestry with the Burmans. This has been reflected in the archaeological record—for example in the history of the coinage issued in the region—and fits with the wider period of regional power enjoyed by the Burmese Pagan Kingdom.[39]

This arrival of the Rakhine was followed by two centuries of close links with the kingdoms of central Burma, during the height of Pagan power. When the Pagan Kingdom fragmented,[40] Arakan regained its independence and engaged in almost six centuries of war, dispute and trade with its neighbours in both Burma and Bengal. From the thirteenth to the end of the seventeenth centuries there were periods of Burmese dominance, periods when Arakan was independent and even brief periods when the regional kings conquered sections of modern-day Bangladesh.

During this time the Mrauk-U dynasty ruled Arakan, presiding over a multi-ethnic mix of the various Chin ethnic groups (Mru, Sak, Kumi), the Rohingyas and Rakhine, and a multi-religious mix of Hindu, Muslim and Buddhist beliefs. Islam was already significant in the region and during the Mrauk-U dynasty it became dominant among the descendants of the earlier Indo–Aryan settlers (that is, it seems, the Rohingyas), even as the Rakhine retained their Buddhist identity.

The court increasingly looked to Bengal and India, and most rulers of the dynasty were Muslims. Many court officials were recruited from northern India. Equally, many mercenaries from Muslim regions served